

Aalok Varma

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Aalok Varma

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CURRENT POSITION

Postdoctoral Fellow, Laboratory of Dr Loren Looger
University of California, San Diego

Sep 2023–Present

EDUCATION

PhD Neuroscience, Laboratory of Dr Vatsala Thirumalai
National Centre for Biological Sciences (Tata Institute of Fundamental Research),
Bangalore

Aug 2015–Aug 2023

Title: Probing Purkinje neuron intrinsic dynamics using experimental and
computational approaches

BSc Biotechnology

Aug 2012–Aug 2015

School of Life Sciences, Manipal University, Manipal

PUBLICATIONS

Primary Research

- Jambor H, Antonietti A, ..., **Varma A**, ..., Weissgerber T. [Creating clear and informative image-based figures for scientific publications](#). *PLoS Biology* (2021)
- Varma A**, Udupa S, Sengupta M, Ghosh P, Thirumalai V. [A machine-learning tool to identify bistable state from calcium imaging data](#). *Journal of Physiology* (2024)
- Narayanan S, **Varma A**, Thirumalai V. [Predictive neural computations in the cerebellum contribute to motor planning and faster behavioral responses in larval zebrafish](#). *Science Advances* (2024)
- Agarwal V, Narayanan S, Sengupta M, **Varma A**, Sarkar S, Chinta S, Thirumalai V. [Highly synchronized inhibition from Purkinje cells entrains cerebellar output in zebrafish](#). *bioRxiv* (2024)
- Dalmeida R, **Varma A**, Anil A, Palakodeti D, Gulyani A. [Temporal integration and active sensing of light in planarians](#). *bioRxiv* (2025)

Advocacy and Science Citizenship

- Varma A**. [Peer Review: Feeling like a 'real' scientist](#). *eLife* (2022)
- Kent. BA, Holman C, ..., **Varma A**, ..., Weissgerber T. [Recommendations for empowering early career researchers to improve research culture and practice](#). *PLoS Biology* (2022)
- Urban L, ... **Varma A**, ... [Point of View: eLife's new model and its impact on science communication](#). *eLife* (2022)

FELLOWSHIPS

Whitman Fellowship, Marine Biological Laboratory (MBL), Woods Hole, MA

Jun 2026–Aug 2026

Kavli-Grass Fellowship, Marine Biological Laboratory (MBL), Woods Hole, MA

May 2024–Aug 2024

HONORS AND AWARDS

Torrey Pines Training Consortium (TPTC) Postdoc PITCH (**Second Place and People's Choice Award**)

Oct 2025

UCSD Postdoc PITCH (**First Place**)

Apr 2025

Society for Neuroscience (SfN) Trainee Professional Development Award (TPDA)

Nov 2023

Carl Storm International Diversity Fellowship, Gordon Research Conference

Jul 2022

CTEP Travel Award, Department of Biotechnology of India (DBT)

Jul 2022

Infosys Leading Edge Travel Award

Jul 2022

International Brain Research Organization (IBRO) Travel Award

Jun 2017

Infosys Travel Award

Jun 2017

Dr TMA Pai Gold Medal, Manipal University

Nov 2015

WORKSHOPS/CONFERENCES ATTENDED

Selected Talk: Cephalopod Neuroscience Gordon Research Conference

Feb 2026

Participant: Society for Neuroscience (SfN) Annual Meeting

Nov 2025

Invited Session Chair: Allen Institute/Kavli Foundation Neurobiology in
Changing Environments Symposium

Apr 2025

Selected Talk: Janelia Conference on Genetic Tools for New Model Organisms

Mar 2025

Participant: <i>Cephalopod Neuroscience Conference and Workshop</i>	Apr 2024
Poster Presenter: <i>Society for Neuroscience (SfN) Annual Meeting</i>	Nov 2023
Selected “Spotlight” Talk: <i>ICTP-ICTS Winter School on Quantitative Systems Biology: Machine Learning in Biology</i>	Dec 2022
Poster Presenter: <i>Gordon Research Conference (GRC) in Molecular and Cellular Neuroscience</i>	Jul 2022
Poster Presenter: <i>Society for Neuroscience (SfN) Annual Meeting</i>	Nov 2021
Selected Participant: <i>Cold Spring Harbor Labs (CSHL) Ion Channels in Synaptic and Neural Circuit Physiology Course</i>	Jun 2017

LEADERSHIP AND SERVICE

Co-chair: <i>Cephalopod Neuroscience Gordon Research Seminars (GRS)</i>	2028 (<i>anticipated</i>)
Ad-hoc Reviewer: <i>Journal of Experimental Biology (JEB), Homeworld Collective Garden Grants, eNeuro</i>	2025-present
Moderator: <i>Undergraduate Summer Research Program, UC San Diego</i>	Aug 2025
Postdoc Representative: <i>Search Committee for Dean of Graduate Education and Postdoctoral Affairs, UC San Diego</i>	Jun 2025
Member and Co-Chair: <i>Early Career Advisory Group (ECAG), eLife</i>	May 2021–Oct 2023
Documentation Team Lead: <i>NCBS/inStem COVID-19 Testing Centre</i>	May 2020–Aug 2020
Community Ambassador: <i>eLife Community Ambassador Program</i>	Apr 2019–Apr 2020

TEACHING AND MENTORSHIP

Instructor: <i>Functional Biodiversity (FunBio) Workshop, Friday Harbor Labs</i>	Jul 2026-Aug 2026
Guest Lecture: <i>BILD 62: Intro to Python for Biologists, UC San Diego</i>	Mar 2026, May 2026
Topic – Clustering algorithms: K-means clustering	
Mentor: <i>Biology Undergraduate and Masters Mentorship Program (BUMMP), UC San Diego</i>	Oct 2023–Oct 2025
Project TA: <i>Neuromatch Academy Computational Neuroscience Summer Course</i>	Jul 2023, Jul 2022
Coordinator and Instructor: <i>Lecture Series in Advanced Biology: Feedback Systems in Biology, NCBS, Bangalore</i>	Jul 2022

OUTREACH

Public Lecture: <i>Sharp Minds, Fleet Science Center</i>	May 2026
Public Lecture: <i>Suds & Science, Fleet Science Center</i>	Mar 2026
Volunteer and Event Lead: <i>Taste of Science, San Diego Chapter</i>	2025–Present
Co-organizer and Presenter: <i>Sympotein, NCBS, Bangalore</i>	2015–2018

LANGUAGES

English	Native
Malayalam	Native
Hindi	Native
Kannada	Fluent
French	Fluent (C2)
Spanish	Intermediate (B1/B2)
Japanese	Beginner (N5)

Last updated: Tuesday, May 26, 2026